

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

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Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track F

International Security & Foreign Policy

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 F track: Security / Foreign Policy. Produce a foreign-policy or national-security memo for an NSC, State Dept, or committee audience.

Use Case Description:

This challenge asks teams to produce a foreign-policy or national-security memo addressing a live geopolitical issue, written for a National Security Council, State Department, or congressional foreign-affairs-committee audience.

Problem Statement:

Producing a decision memo for a National Security Council or State Department audience.

- Select a focus: great-power competition, alliance management, non-proliferation/arms control, sanctions policy, cybersecurity/critical infrastructure threats, or humanitarian/refugee policy.
- Assess the current state of play (recent developments, key actors, existing US posture).
- Identify US interests and constraints (legal, budgetary, alliance commitments).
- Draft a policy option set with a recommended course of action.
- War-game a plausible adversarial response to the recommended option.

Possible Approaches:

- NSC memo — a decision memo format (options with pros/cons) for a senior decision-maker.
- Scenario/war-game — build the analysis around a specific crisis scenario.
- Alliance-coordination — focus on multilateral coordination (e.g., NATO or Five Eyes).
- Sanctions/economic statecraft — design a sanctions or export-control package and assess effectiveness.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page decision memo (options format)

- One-page executive summary
- Slide deck (8–10 slides)
- A short risk register (top 3–5 risks of the recommended course)
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Run a tabletop exercise/simulation with the team playing stakeholders
- Draft talking points for a press briefing or testimony
- Open-source intelligence (OSINT) summary using only public reporting
- A red-team memo arguing the adversary's likely strategy

Platforms and Tools:

- Data/reporting: State Dept press briefings, DoD public statements, think tank trackers (CSIS, CNAS, Brookings, Belfer Center)
- Legislative tracking: Congress.gov
- Drafting/collaboration: Google Docs, shared repo

Judging Criteria:

- Strategic soundness & feasibility — **25%**
- Use of credible, current sourcing — **20%**
- Clarity of options and tradeoffs — **20%**
- Anticipation of second-order/adversarial effects — **20%**
- Presentation quality — **15%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Open-source, publicly available information only — no classified, leaked, or non-public government material.
- Do not fabricate quotes or statements attributed to real officials.
- This challenge is strategic/policy analysis only, not operational planning.
- Disclose AI tool use.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.